

STAGE SEVEN • HARD SKILLS

FIRSTS

FAQ

Anticipated participant questions and suggested facilitator responses

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • FAQ

Stage Seven • Hard Skills

PURPOSE

These are the questions that come up most often across cohorts of Stage Seven, with a suggested facilitator response for each. Given this stage's scale, several questions here address the volume and pacing directly, not just individual FIRST content.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q1. This stage feels enormous — do I need to be equally strong at everything by the end?

A: No. The closing self-assessment (K56) and development plan (K60) are specifically designed to help you identify a few priority areas, not to expect equal mastery across all ninety FIRSTS. Uneven strength across a stage this broad is the norm, not a problem.

Q2. What if I don't have access to a real dataset, project, or portfolio to use throughout a section?

A: Ask your facilitator for a sample dataset, project brief, or starter portfolio template. Using a provided example is a completely reasonable substitute for a personal one — the skill-building value is nearly identical.

Q3. I'm not technical at all — is this stage going to be genuinely inaccessible to me?

A: This stage is designed for genuine beginners across most of its FIRSTS. K20 (Basic Coding or Logic) and K47 (Task Automation) are the most technically demanding, and both include a low bar for a first attempt. If you're still stuck, that's exactly what K54's troubleshooting approach and your facilitator are for.

Q4. Some of these FIRSTS (K37, K52, K80) run over multiple days or ongoing periods — how do I manage that alongside everything else?

A: These are intentionally lightweight to maintain — a few minutes of daily tracking, or picking up a paused mini project. Treat them as a background thread running alongside the rest of the stage's more concentrated session work, not an additional major time commitment.

Q5. What if my group role-play (negotiation, delegation, meeting) feels awkward or fake?

A: That's a completely normal reaction to practicing something new out loud in a low-stakes setting. The awkwardness itself often fades with a second attempt, and the skill genuinely transfers even when the scenario feels artificial.

Q6. K90 asks me to attend a real showcase event — what if none exist near me or on the program's timeline?

A: Talk to your facilitator about alternatives — a genuine virtual showcase, a smaller peer demo day organized within the cohort, or a relevant industry event count as reasonable substitutes for a large, formal showcase.